Winning Without the Most Votes

First-Past-The-Post and the Quality of Voters' Representation in Canadian Federal Elections (2015–2025)

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1. Introduction

For this essay, I have chosen to study the electoral system used in Canadian federal elections and its impact on the quality of voters' representation. I initially studied the federal elections of 2015 and 2019, and I have updated the analysis with the elections of 2021 and 2025. I did not include provincial or local elections because their electoral rules vary from one jurisdiction to another. The paper proceeds as follows. First, I define the electoral system used in Canada. Second, I analyse the 2015 federal election and give concrete details about the impact of the electoral system on voters' representation. Third, I analyse the 2019 election, and fourth, the more recent elections of 2021 and 2025. Fifth, I discuss the consequences of the electoral system. Finally, I make some recommendations to improve the quality of voters' representation.

Canadian federal elections are held under the First-Past-The-Post system (FPTP), also called the Winner-Takes-All model, in single-member districts (SMD). This means that the candidate who receives the most votes in a district, even without an absolute majority, wins the seat allocated to that district. This electoral system therefore has an impact on the party system and, consequently, on voters' choices. According to Duverger's law, FPTP tends to produce a two-party system in which two main parties compete for power, governing either with a majority or as a minority government dependent on the support of a third or fourth party.[1] Small parties are under-represented, because it is very difficult for them to win a plurality of the votes in a district; anticipating this, some of their supporters vote strategically for one of the main contenders.[2]

In this paper, I examine how votes are translated into seats in the House of Commons, how this seat distribution affects voters' representation and, if there is an impact, how it could be improved.

[1] Maurice Duverger, *Les partis politiques* (Paris : Armand Colin, 1951); Gary W. Cox, *Making Votes Count: Strategic Coordination in the World's Electoral Systems* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1997).
[2] André Blais and Arianna Degan, « L'étude empirique du vote stratégique », *L'Actualité économique* 93, no. 1-2 (2017): 72.

2. The First-Past-The-Post system

The First-Past-The-Post system is a majoritarian system that produces a distribution of seats which is not proportional to the votes cast. The candidate who receives the most votes wins the seat (in Canadian federal elections, each district elects only one member). This system therefore tends to produce a two-party system in which two parties dominate electoral competition and one of them often obtains a majority of seats. However, FPTP does not always give the majority of seats to the party that obtained the most votes. For example, if party A receives 51% of the votes and party B 48%, party B can still win a majority of seats if its votes are distributed more efficiently across districts, because votes are not translated proportionally into seats. In Canada, this happened in 2019 and 2021, when the Liberal Party won the most seats while receiving fewer votes than the Conservative Party (see sections 4 and 5).

FPTP is also often associated with lower turnout than proportional representation (PR).[3] Comparative research nevertheless shows that this effect is modest and is found mainly in established Western democracies.[4] In an experimental study, André Blais and his colleagues emphasised that "normative considerations play a larger role in more complicated systems, which make it more difficult for voters to realize that their vote is unlikely to substantially affect the outcome of the election."[5] Moreover, FPTP does not necessarily produce more strategic voting than proportional systems: strategic voting also exists under PR, where voters take into account the formation of coalitions and electoral thresholds.[6]

The drawing of electoral boundaries is another major issue under FPTP. In its American form, gerrymandering occurs when incumbents redraw district boundaries to favour one party over another by adding or removing groups of voters. In Canada, this risk is limited, because federal boundaries have been drawn since 1964 by independent commissions in each province.[7] The issue in Canada is rather the unequal population of districts, which can affect the quality of

[3] André Blais and R. Kenneth Carty, "Does Proportional Representation Foster Voter Turnout?," *European Journal of Political Research* 18, no. 2 (1990): 167–181.
[4] André Blais, "What Affects Voter Turnout?," *Annual Review of Political Science* 9 (2006): 111–125.
[5] André Blais et al., "To Vote or to Abstain? An Experimental Study of First Past the Post and PR Elections," Cahier de recherche no. 2011-15 (Paris: École Polytechnique / CNRS, August 2011), 15. Published as André Blais et al., "To Vote or to Abstain? An Experimental Test of Rational Calculus in First Past the Post and PR Elections," *Electoral Studies* 36 (2014): 39–50.
[6] Blais and Degan, « L'étude empirique du vote stratégique », 73.
[7] *Electoral Boundaries Readjustment Act*, R.S.C. 1985, c. E-3.

representation.[8] Finally, FPTP tends to penalise new parties whose support is spread evenly across the country, while it can favour regionalist parties whose votes are geographically concentrated, such as the Bloc Québécois.[9] On the other hand, an advantage of the First-Past-The-Post system is that it tends to produce single-party governments that are more efficient and more clearly accountable to voters.[10]

3. The 2015 federal election

I begin with the 2015 federal election, which elected the members of the House of Commons. In this case, the gap between seat share and vote share is large. The House of Commons then had 338 seats. The Liberal Party received 39.5% of the votes but won 184 of the 338 seats. It therefore obtained a majority and did not need the support of another party (170 seats were needed for a majority, i.e. 50% + 1). The Conservative Party received 31.9% of the votes but won only 99 seats (29.3% of the seats). The New Democratic Party (NDP) and the Bloc Québécois (BQ) were both under-represented: the NDP received 19.7% of the votes but won only 44 seats (13.0%), and the BQ received 4.7% of the votes but won only 10 seats (3.0%).[11] The Liberal Party was advantaged: with 39.5% of the votes, it obtained 54.4% of the seats, a bonus of about 15 percentage points.

The NDP and the BQ, on the other hand, were disadvantaged, losing about 6.7 and 1.7 percentage points respectively. Again, we can see that FPTP has an impact on the quality of voters' representation. This phenomenon is explained by the district magnitude (a single seat per district) and by the geographical distribution of each party's votes across districts.[12]

In many districts, therefore, the seat is won by a candidate supported by a minority of voters, which is a paradox of the majoritarian system. For instance, in the district of Montmagny–L'Islet–Kamouraska–Rivière-du-Loup, the Conservative candidate won with only 29.0% of the

[8] Paul E. J. Thomas, Peter John Loewen and Michael K. MacKenzie, "Fair Isn't Always Equal: Constituency Population and the Quality of Representation in Canada," *Canadian Journal of Political Science / Revue canadienne de science politique* 46, no. 2 (2013): 273–293.
[9] Florence Faucher, « Le système électoral britannique », in *Le mode de scrutin fait-il l'élection ?*, ed. Pascal Delwit and Jean-Michel De Waele (Bruxelles : Éditions de l'Université de Bruxelles, 2000), 50–67; Cox, *Making Votes Count*.
[10] Faucher, « Le système électoral britannique », 50–67.
[11] Elections Canada, *Forty-Second General Election 2015: Official Voting Results* (Ottawa: Elections Canada). Seat shares are my own calculation (seats/338).
[12] Cox, *Making Votes Count*; Thomas, Loewen and MacKenzie, "Fair Isn't Always Equal," 273–293.

votes, 272 votes ahead of the Liberal candidate (28.4%). This raises a problem of representation: 71% of the voters in this district supported another candidate.[13] However, this voting system does not have only "negative" effects, because it is often credited with producing stable, accountable and strong governments.[14]

4. The 2019 federal election

In 2019, the Liberal Party lost its majority but formed a minority government. It obtained 33.1% of the votes (6,018,728), while the Conservative Party received 34.3% (6,239,227). As in the previous election, however, the electoral system advantaged the Liberal Party: it won 157 districts with only 33.1% of the votes cast, which corresponds to 46.4% of the seats in the House of Commons. The Conservative Party won 121 seats (35.8%). For this party, the gap between vote share and seat share is small, but it is still slightly positive. The Bloc Québécois also won more seats than its vote share would justify: 32 seats (9.5%) with only 7.6% of the votes. The parties that suffered most from the electoral system in this election were the NDP and the Green Party. The NDP won 24 seats (7.1%) with 16.0% of the votes, and the Green Party only 3 seats (0.9%) with 6.5% of the votes.[15]

In many districts, the winner obtained only around a third of the votes. In Yukon, for example, the Liberal candidate won the seat with 33.5% of the votes, only 153 votes ahead of the Conservative candidate (32.7%).[16]

Table 1. 2019 federal election (338 seats; one independent was also elected). Source: Elections Canada; seat shares calculated by the author.

Party	**Vote share (%)**	**Seat share (%)**	**Seats**
Liberal	33.1	46.4	157
Conservative	34.3	35.8	121

[13] « Canada Votes 2015 », CBC News, accessed December 14, 2019, https://www.cbc.ca/includes/federalelection/dashboard/; Elections Canada, *Forty-Second General Election 2015: Official Voting Results*.
[14] Pascal Delwit, *Introduction à la science politique* (Bruxelles : Éditions de l'Université de Bruxelles, 2013), 173.
[15] Elections Canada, *Forty-Third General Election 2019: Official Voting Results* (Ottawa: Elections Canada); « Canada Votes 2019 », CBC News, accessed December 14, 2019, https://newsinteractives.cbc.ca/elections/federal/2019/results/. Seat shares are my own calculation (seats/338).
[16] "Verified Election Results Show Bagnell Won by 153 Votes," *Yukon News*, October 2019, https://www.yukon-news.com/federal-election/verified-election-results-show-bagnell-won-by-153-votes-6998458.

Party	Vote share (%)	Seat share (%)	Seats
New Democratic	16.0	7.1	24
Bloc Québécois	7.6	9.5	32
Green	6.5	0.9	3

5. The 2021 and 2025 federal elections

The 2021 election confirmed the pattern observed in 2019. The Liberal Party again won the most seats (160, i.e. 47.3%) with fewer votes than the Conservative Party (32.6% against 33.7%), and again formed a minority government. The NDP won 25 seats (7.4%) with 17.8% of the votes, while the People's Party of Canada received 4.9% of the votes but won no seat. Turnout fell to 62.6%.[17]

The federal election of 28 April 2025 took place with a House of Commons enlarged to 343 seats following the decennial redistribution. Competition became strongly concentrated on the two main parties, which together received 85% of the votes. The Liberal Party won 169 seats (49.3%) with 43.8% of the votes and the Conservative Party 144 seats (42.0%) with 41.3%. The smaller parties were severely affected: the NDP won only 7 seats (2.0%) with 6.3% of the votes, while the Bloc Québécois, with exactly the same vote share (6.3%), won 22 seats (6.4%) because its votes are concentrated in Quebec. The Green Party won a single seat with 1.2% of the votes. Turnout rose to 69.0% of registered electors.[18] The result was also extremely close in several districts: in Milton East–Halton Hills South, for example, the Liberal candidate won by 21 votes.[19]

[17] Elections Canada, *Forty-Fourth General Election 2021: Official Voting Results* (Ottawa: Elections Canada); Elections Canada, "Voter Turnout at Federal Elections and Referendums," accessed October 22, 2026, https://www.elections.ca/content.aspx?section=ele&dir=turn&document=index&lang=e.
[18] Elections Canada, *Forty-Fifth General Election 2025: Official Voting Results* (Ottawa: Elections Canada), tables 4, 7 and 8, https://elections.ca/res/rep/off/ovrGE45/62/table8E.html. Seat shares are my own calculation (seats/343).
[19] "Liberal Candidate Wins Milton East–Halton Hills South Riding by 21 Votes after Official Recount," CTV News, May 16, 2025, https://www.ctvnews.ca/kitchener/article/liberal-candidate-wins-milton-east-halton-hills-south-riding-by-21-votes-after-official-recount/.

Table 2. 2025 federal election (343 seats). Source: Elections Canada; seat shares calculated by the author.

Party	**Vote share (%)**	**Seat share (%)**	**Seats**
Liberal	43.8	49.3	169
Conservative	41.3	42.0	144
Bloc Québécois	6.3	6.4	22
New Democratic	6.3	2.0	7
Green	1.2	0.3	1

These recent elections show that the degree of distortion under FPTP depends on the structure of competition. Using the Gallagher least-squares index,[20] I calculate a disproportionality of about 12 in 2015 and 2019 and about 13 in 2021, but only about 5 in 2025, when voters concentrated on the two main parties. Even in 2025, however, the comparison between the NDP and the BQ shows that the geographical distribution of votes, rather than their number, determines representation.

6. Consequences

Overall, we have seen the impact of the electoral system on the quality of voters' representation. As shown above, in the Canadian case the geographical distribution of votes across districts shapes election results. There is a misrepresentation of voters: parties are either over-represented (the Liberal Party and the BQ) or under-represented (the NDP and the Greens). Smaller parties have less chance of winning seats because only one seat is at stake in each district, which intensifies competition in each district (even at the intra-party level, since each party presents only one candidate per district).

In many cases, the candidate elected in a district does not have a majority of the votes. This is one of the main characteristics of FPTP.

This electoral system is also associated with lower turnout. In Canada, federal turnout was 68.3% in 2015, 67.0% in 2019, 62.6% in 2021 and 69.0% in 2025,[21] which is lower than in many

[20] Michael Gallagher, "Proportionality, Disproportionality and Electoral Systems," *Electoral Studies* 10, no. 1 (1991): 33–51. The values are my own calculations from the official results cited in notes 11, 15, 17 and 18.
[21] Elections Canada, "Voter Turnout at Federal Elections and Referendums."

Western European democracies using PR, although the comparative literature warns that this difference is modest and depends on context.[22] According to Dow, the less proportional the translation of votes into seats, the more parties tend to cluster near the centre of the ideological space.[23] Candidates are therefore more likely to target the median voter, so that voters far from the median are less heard by parties and candidates under FPTP than under PR. According to Bernauer, Giger and Rosset, low-income citizens are better represented in proportional systems with larger district magnitudes than under FPTP (low-income voters are not, however, necessarily non-median voters).[24]

Finally, the winner-takes-all system does not always generate more strategic voting or protest voting than proportional systems.[25]

7. Conclusion

To sum up, we have seen that in Canada the electoral system has an important impact on representation. There is a misrepresentation of voters under the First-Past-The-Post system: some voters are poorly represented, and in many districts the seat is won by a candidate supported by a minority of voters. It is also important to emphasise that low-income voters are better represented in proportional systems than in single-member district systems.[26]

In the next section, I therefore make some recommendations for institutional reform intended to improve voters' representation. These recommendations focus primarily on voters' representation, but other variables must be taken into account: the efficiency of the regime, the challenge of drawing electoral boundaries and the uneven distribution of the population across areas and regions.[27]

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[22] Blais, "What Affects Voter Turnout?," 111–125; Blais and Carty, "Does Proportional Representation Foster Voter Turnout?," 167–181.
[23] Jay K. Dow, "Party-System Extremism in Majoritarian and Proportional Electoral Systems," *British Journal of Political Science* 41, no. 2 (2011): 341–361.
[24] Julian Bernauer, Nathalie Giger and Jan Rosset, "Mind the Gap: Do Proportional Electoral Systems Foster a More Equal Representation of Women and Men, Poor and Rich?," *International Political Science Review* 36, no. 1 (2015): 78–98.
[25] Blais and Degan, « L'étude empirique du vote stratégique », 74.
[26] Bernauer, Giger and Rosset, "Mind the Gap," 78–98.
[27] Thomas, Loewen and MacKenzie, "Fair Isn't Always Equal," 288.

8. Recommendations

The First-Past-The-Post system has advantages and disadvantages, but its main disadvantage is that it does not produce a proportional representation of voters. Furthermore, it can lead to a situation in which a party that did not receive the most votes nevertheless wins the most seats in Parliament, as in 2019 and 2021. Therefore, in order to obtain a more proportional relationship between votes and seats, I propose two electoral systems.

Other options are sometimes discussed, such as electronic voting or preferential (ranked) ballots, in which voters rank candidates in order of preference. However, electronic voting is a voting method and not an electoral system, while the preferential ballot in single-member districts (the alternative vote, used in Australia's House of Representatives) remains a majoritarian system that does not correct disproportionality.[28] For these reasons, I do not retain them here.

The proportional system

In a proportional system, the main objective is to obtain an assembly whose composition is as close as possible to the distribution of the votes.[29] We could therefore replace the majoritarian system with a proportional one. Most proportional systems are list systems: each party presents a list of candidates, and voters vote for a list rather than for an individual candidate.

Each party could thus present a list in every district. Voters would choose among the lists, and one or several candidates from each list would be elected depending on the votes received. This would allow more parties, including small ones, to enter Parliament and would of course improve the representation of voters. However, if the current districts were kept and each elected several representatives, the size of the House of Commons would increase considerably. If, instead, the boundaries were redrawn to create larger multi-member districts, the proximity between representatives and voters would be weakened.[30]

In fact, with larger districts, representatives would not be as close to voters as before. On the other hand, if the boundaries were not redrawn, the House of Commons would become much larger: with three or four members per district instead of one, it would grow from 343 to over a

[28] David M. Farrell, *Electoral Systems: A Comparative Introduction*, 2nd ed. (Basingstoke: Palgrave Macmillan, 2011).
[29] Delwit, *Introduction à la science politique*, 175.
[30] Faucher, « Le système électoral britannique », 50–67.

thousand members, which is hardly workable. Since the objective of this recommendation is to correct the problem of representation, the best compromise is to create relatively small multi-member districts. Carey and Hix show that proportional systems with low-to-moderate district magnitudes retain most of the representational benefits of PR while limiting party fragmentation, an electoral "sweet spot".[31] At the same time, voters' participation in decision-making could be encouraged through tools of direct democracy, such as referendums. Any redrawing of boundaries should remain the responsibility of the independent electoral boundaries commissions, working with experts, to ensure neutrality and a good knowledge of the reality on the ground.[32]

Canada already has some experience of this debate. In 2016, the House of Commons Special Committee on Electoral Reform recommended adopting a proportional system with a Gallagher index of 5 or less and submitting it to a referendum, but the government abandoned the reform in February 2017.[33] At the provincial level, voters in British Columbia rejected a change to proportional representation for the third time in 2018.[34] These experiences show that a transition to PR requires broad public support. Nevertheless, the proportional system remains a credible alternative to FPTP in Canada (with or without a redrawing of electoral districts and district magnitudes).

The mixed-member proportional system

Mixed-member proportional representation (MMP) is a mixed electoral system that combines elements of majoritarian and proportional systems: some members are elected in single-member districts, while list seats are allocated so that the overall result is proportional. I put MMP as a second recommendation because it can improve the quality of voters' representation while preserving the local link between voters and their representative. It combines positive elements of both majoritarian and proportional systems and tries to limit their disadvantages. Another

[31] John M. Carey and Simon Hix, "The Electoral Sweet Spot: Low-Magnitude Proportional Electoral Systems," *American Journal of Political Science* 55, no. 2 (2011): 383–397.
[32] *Electoral Boundaries Readjustment Act*, R.S.C. 1985, c. E-3.
[33] House of Commons of Canada, Special Committee on Electoral Reform, *Strengthening Democracy in Canada: Principles, Process and Public Engagement for Electoral Reform*, Third Report (Ottawa, December 2016); "Opposition Accuses Trudeau of 'Betrayal' as Liberals Abandon Promise of Electoral Reform," CBC News, February 1, 2017, https://www.cbc.ca/1.3961736.
[34] "B.C. Votes to Keep First-Past-the-Post Electoral System," CBC News, December 20, 2018, https://www.cbc.ca/1.4954538.

important point is that MMP is the system most preferred by electoral system experts.[35] Moreover, several of the major electoral reforms of the 1990s moved towards mixed-member systems, the most notable case being New Zealand, which adopted MMP in 1993.[36] Finally, this system can lead to a more representative system without losing government efficiency.[37]

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[36] Matthew Søberg Shugart and Martin P. Wattenberg, eds., *Mixed-Member Electoral Systems: The Best of Both Worlds?* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2001).
[37] Bowler, Farrell and Pettitt, "Expert Opinion on Electoral Systems," 3–19; Carey and Hix, "The Electoral Sweet Spot," 383–397.

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